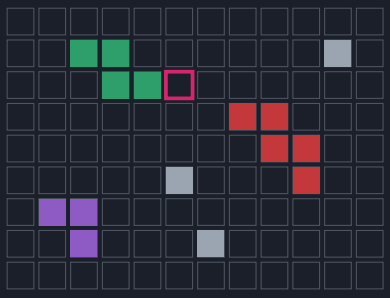
SYN-ACK WIRE

[RULE BOOK]



Seven syndicates. One region. Every node for sale.

2–6 Access Cowboys // networked play with bots

An unofficial cyberpunk re-skin of *Acquire* by Sid Sackson.

1 The Wire

The region's network used to belong to someone. Now it belongs to everyone: hospitals, traffic control, corporate tenants, vending kiosks and city utilities, all crammed onto the same racks and the same fiber. Nobody owns the region as a whole. A consortium of backbone carriers keeps the packets moving and asks no questions.

You are an **Access Cowboy**. You break into nodes, plant persistent **spikes**, and when two of your footholds touch, you have something worth selling: a **hive**. You broker it to one of seven crime syndicates, take your cut in their crypto, and watch the price climb as their hive spreads across the Grid.

Syndicates do not share. When two hives collide, the bigger one **hivejacks** the smaller and the people holding the loser's crypto get paid out, or wiped out. Sooner or later the carriers lose patience and **null-route** the whole region. When the routes go dark, the cowboy holding the most ¥ wins.

Object of the game

Have the most new yen (¥) when the region is null-routed.

2 What's in the Game

SYN-ACK WIRE is played on a computer; the game server keeps track of everything below.

The Grid 108 nodes in 9 rows (0–8) and 12 columns (A–L). A node is named column first, then row: A0 is the top-left corner, L8 the bottom-right.

Exploits 108 of them, one for each node. An exploit can only be run against the node it is written for. Each cowboy holds 6 exploits, called their **exploit kit**. Your exploit kit is secret.

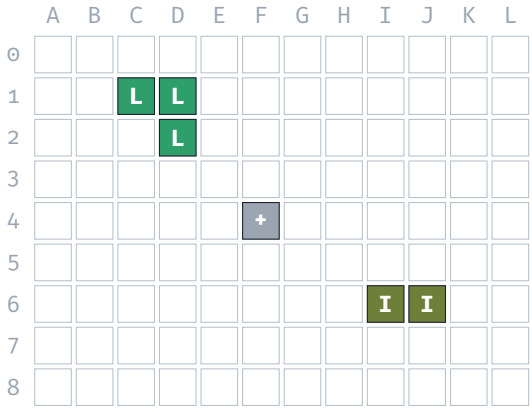
Syndicates Seven crime syndicates, each with its own crypto. Only one hive per syndicate can be on the Grid at a time.

Crypto 25 of each syndicate's crypto. Whatever no cowboy owns is held by the Darkpool.

The Darkpool The bank. It sells crypto, buys it back, and pays out bonuses. It never lends.

New yen Each cowboy starts with ¥6,000.

Reading the Grid



Each syndicate is shown by its letter. `+`: a lone **spike** (F4). `L`: Lotus-12 Triad, a hive of 3 nodes (C1, D1, D2). `I`: Iron Vector, a hive of 2 nodes (I6, J6). Only up, down, left and right count as touching; diagonals never do.

3 The Seven Syndicates

Every syndicate's crypto follows the same rules. What differs is the **tier**: how much its crypto is worth for a hive of a given size. Low-tier crews are cheap to buy into; high-tier powers are expensive but pay big. The letter is how the syndicate appears on the Grid.

	Syndicate	Tier	Word on the wire
G	Ghost//Modem	Low	Old-school phreakers squatting in dead telco switches. Still whistle 2600 Hz for fun.
R	Rat King Cartel	Low	Data smugglers in the maintenance tunnels. Carry stolen drives in their mouths. Metaphorically. Mostly.
D	Church of the Holy Daemon	Mid	Believe a background process achieved godhood in '99. Pray in cron. Tithes are recurring.
I	Iron Vector	Mid	Paramilitary arms brokers. Drone swarms for hire, invoices in triplicate, refunds never.
B	Bratva 404	Mid	Eastern-bloc mob. People who cross them become "not found."
L	Lotus-12 Triad	High	Has kept its debts in spreadsheets since the 1980s. Every favor is a cell; every cell has a formula.
O	Obsidian Ledger	High	Faceless cabal of former central bankers. They run the Darkpool.

4 Setup

1. Every cowboy gets ¥6,000. The Darkpool holds all the crypto at the start.
2. **Turn order.** Each cowboy is dealt one exploit, and it is spiked onto the Grid at once. The cowboy whose spike is in the lowest-numbered row goes first; if two share a row, the one closer to column A wins the tie. Play then continues around the table in seat order. These opening spikes stay on the Grid and do not form hives, even if they happen to touch.
3. Each cowboy is dealt 6 exploits into their exploit kit.

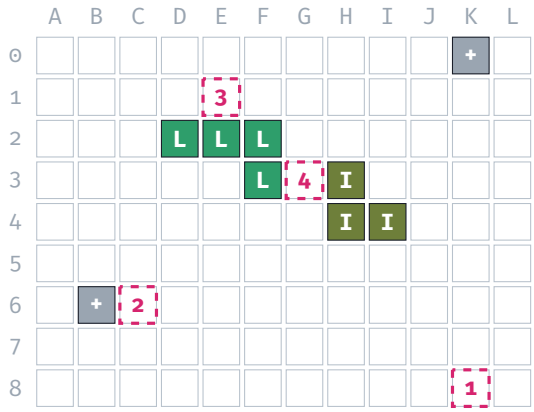
5 Playing a Turn

On your turn, do these three things in order:

1. **Spike a node.** Run one exploit from your exploit kit and place a spike on its node.
2. **Buy crypto.** Buy up to 3 crypto from the Darkpool (optional).
3. **Pick up a fresh exploit.** Draw a new exploit to bring your exploit kit back to 6.

1. Spike a node

Where your spike lands decides what happens. It will do exactly one of these:



1. **Nothing.** K8 touches nothing. The spike just sits there.
2. **Infiltration.** C6 touches the lone spike on B6. A new hive is born.
3. **Spread.** E1 touches the Lotus-12 Triad hive. It grows to 5 nodes.
4. **Hivejack.** G3 touches both Lotus-12 Triad (4 nodes) and Iron Vector (3 nodes). Lotus-12 Triad absorbs Iron Vector.

Infiltration: founding a hive

If your spike touches one or more lone spikes, and no hive, you have founded a new **hive**. Choose any syndicate that does not have a hive on the Grid and **broker** the hive to it. Your spike and every lone spike connected to it become that syndicate's hive.

As your **finder's cut**, take 1 crypto of that syndicate from the Darkpool for free. If the Darkpool has none left, you get nothing.

BLOCKED EXPLOITS

If all seven syndicates already have hives on the Grid, an exploit that would found an eighth hive cannot be run. It stays in your exploit kit until a syndicate leaves the Grid. The game marks these for you.

Spread: growing a hive

If your spike touches exactly one hive, it joins that hive. Any lone spikes connected to your spike join too. The hive is now bigger, and its crypto is worth more.

Hivejack: merging hives

If your spike touches two or more different hives, they collide and the biggest one **hivejacks** the others. Your new spike does not count toward any hive's size while deciding this. Work through these steps:

1. **Who absorbs whom.** The hive with more nodes is the **absorber**; the smaller is **absorbed**. If they are the same size, you choose which syndicate survives.
2. **Find the ROOT and SUDO.** Look at who holds the absorbed syndicate's crypto. The cowboy with the most is **ROOT**; the one with the second most is **SUDO**.
3. **Payouts.** The Darkpool pays the ROOT and SUDO bonuses from the reference chart, using the absorbed hive's size just before the hivejack. See *Splitting payouts* below for ties.

4. **Crypto decisions.** Starting with you and going around the table, every cowboy holding the absorbed syndicate's crypto chooses what to do with it, in any mix:
    - **Cash out**: sell crypto to the Darkpool at the absorbed syndicate's price (its size before the hivejack).
    - **Swap**: trade 2 absorbed crypto for 1 crypto of the absorber, as long as the Darkpool has absorber crypto left.
    - **HODL**: keep the crypto. It is now **flatlined** and worthless, unless that syndicate is brokered a new hive later, when it comes **back from the flatline**.
5. **Clean up.** The absorbed hive's nodes, your spike, and any connected lone spikes all join the absorber. The absorbed syndicate leaves the Grid and can be brokered again later.

EXAMPLE: A TIED ROOT

Iron Vector (3 nodes, mid tier) is hivejacked. At 3 nodes, mid-tier crypto is ¥400, so the ROOT bonus is ¥4,000 and SUDO is ¥2,000. NEON_MAMBA and ZER0COOL each hold 4 Iron Vector crypto; RAZORGRL holds 2.
NEON_MAMBA and ZER0COOL tie for ROOT, so they share ROOT + SUDO: ¥6,000 split two ways, ¥3,000 each. Nobody is paid SUDO, so RAZORGRL gets nothing.
Then, in turn order, NEON_MAMBA chooses to cash out 2 of them for ¥800 and swap the other 2 for 1 Lotus-12 Triad crypto.

Splitting payouts

- **Tie for ROOT:** add the ROOT and SUDO bonuses together and split them evenly among the tied cowboys, rounding each share *up* to the next ¥100. No SUDO bonus is paid.
- **Tie for SUDO:** split the SUDO bonus evenly among the tied cowboys, rounding each share up to the next ¥100.
- **One cowboy is the only holder:** they collect both ROOT and SUDO.
- **Nobody holds the crypto:** nothing is paid.

EXAMPLE: ROUNDING UP

A 2-node mid-tier hive is absorbed (ROOT ¥3,000, SUDO ¥1,500). Two cowboys tie for ROOT: ¥4,500 split two ways is ¥2,250, rounded up to ¥2,300 each.

Black ICE: safe hives

Once a hive reaches **11 or more nodes**, its syndicate wraps it in **Black ICE**. A Black ICE hive can never be absorbed. It can still absorb smaller hives that are not Black ICE.

An exploit that would join two Black ICE hives can never be run. It is **patched out**. The game marks it for you.

Multi-way hivejacks

If your spike touches three or four hives at once, resolve them one at a time. The largest hive absorbs the second largest (do all five steps), then the now-bigger absorber takes on the next largest, and so on. If two of the smaller hives are tied in size, you choose which is absorbed first. If the two largest are tied, you choose the absorber.

2. Buy crypto

After placing your spike, you may buy up to 3 crypto from the Darkpool, in any mix of syndicates. You can only buy crypto of syndicates that have a hive on the Grid. The price is set by the hive's current size (see the reference chart), so a spread or hivejack you just caused changes the price before you buy.

You cannot buy more than the Darkpool has, and you cannot spend money you do not have. There are no loans.

3. Pick up a fresh exploit

Draw one exploit so your exploit kit is back to 6. If no exploits are left to draw, skip this step.

BURN THE KIT

If, at the start of your turn, none of the exploits in your exploit kit can be run, reveal your exploit kit, discard it, and draw 6 new exploits. Then take your turn as normal. The game does this automatically.

6 Ending the Game

After placing your spike, if either of these is true, you may **call the null-route**:

- **Total Compromise**: any hive has 41 or more nodes.
- **Lockdown**: every hive on the Grid is Black ICE.

Calling it is your choice; you may keep playing instead. If you call it, finish your turn (you may still buy crypto). Then the carriers null-route the region and the game ends.

```
[!]  NULL-ROUTE NEO-KANSAI-1:  UNJACK!
```

GRID STALL

If a full round goes by in which no cowboy can run an exploit (every exploit kit is empty or holds only blocked or patched out exploits), the Grid can never change again. The carriers seal the region and the game ends at once, without anyone calling it. Go straight to the final cash out.

The final cash out

1. Pay ROOT and SUDO bonuses for every hive still on the Grid, exactly as in a hivejack.
2. Every cowboy sells all their crypto to the Darkpool at its current price, starting with the smallest hive.
3. Flatlined crypto (from syndicates not on the Grid) is worth nothing.

The cowboy with the most ¥ wins. Ties share the win.

7 Network Play

SYN-ACK WIRE is played over the network, with each cowboy at their own machine.

- **Bots fill empty seats.** Start a game with as many humans as you have; bots take the rest.
- **Shot clock.** Every decision has a time limit. If yours runs out, your bot makes that one decision for you.
- **Dropped connection.** If you drop off the network, your bot plays your seat until you reconnect, then hands it back. Your exploit kit, crypto and ¥ are waiting for you.

8 Frequently Asked Questions

What if I run out of new yen? Keep running exploits. You just can't buy crypto until a payout or cash out puts ¥ back in your account.

Can I see other cowboys' crypto? Yes. Crypto holdings are public. Exploit kits are secret.

Does my free finder's cut count toward ROOT and SUDO? Yes. It counts like any other crypto you hold.

Can a flatlined syndicate come back? Yes. Once a syndicate leaves the Grid it can be brokered a new hive. Any crypto you HODLed is worth its price again.

Do I have to call the null-route? No. If you are behind, keep playing and hope to catch up.

9 Where the Money Comes From

New cowboys often feel busy without knowing what they are building toward. It helps to know where the ¥ actually comes from.

IN ONE LINE

Exploits don't make money; crypto does. You get paid when a hive you lead is absorbed, or when the game ends. Running exploits is how you decide which hives get absorbed, and when.

Founding is about position, not money

An infiltration earns only the finder's cut: one free crypto, worth ¥200–¥400 while the hive is small. Its real value is that you choose which syndicate comes up, and you are first to buy its crypto, at the lowest price it will ever have. Founding is the cheapest way to become ROOT of a hive.

The big money: ROOT and SUDO

- **The absorbed hive pays, not the absorber.** This is the part new cowboys get backwards. At a hivejack, only the syndicate being swallowed pays its ROOT and SUDO bonuses.
- **The bonuses are large.** ROOT pays ten times the crypto's price and SUDO five times. At a price of ¥600, ROOT is ¥6,000, as much as your whole starting stake.
- **So the classic play** is to lead a small or medium hive that sits next to a bigger one, then run the exploit that joins them, on your terms.

The rest: the crypto itself

- **At a hivejack**, the absorbed crypto can be cashed out, swapped 2 for 1 into the absorber, or kept. A swap is how you climb into a big hive without spending ¥.
- **At the null-route**, every hive still on the Grid pays ROOT and SUDO, and all crypto is sold at its final price. A Black ICE hive can never be absorbed, so it pays only now, but by now it is usually big.

Why it is hard to see: cash is the real limit

You start with ¥6,000 and may buy only 3 crypto a turn, and nothing you hold pays until a hivejack or the end. An early bonus counts twice: it pays you, and it pays for the crypto that wins the next fight for ROOT.

EXAMPLE: FINDER'S CUT VS. ROOT

Early on you found a low-tier hive: your finder's cut is worth ¥200. You keep buying, and when the hive has grown to 5 nodes you hold 4 of its crypto and nobody else holds more than 2. A larger hive sits one node away, and you hold that exploit. You run it: ¥5,000 for ROOT, then you cash out your 4 crypto at ¥500 each for ¥2,000 more. The infiltration was the doorway; the hivejack was the payday.

10 Tips

None of this is a rule. It is what experienced cowboys tend to know.

Early: get hives on the Grid

- **Found hives whenever you can.** The finder's cut is a free crypto, and you can buy 3 more on the same turn, while the price is at its lowest. That is a head start on ROOT that nobody else gets.
- **Small hives pay too.** A hive that gets hivejacked early still pays its ROOT and SUDO. Don't ignore a hive just because it will never be big.
- **Don't stretch yourself thin.** With only 3 crypto a turn, being ROOT of one syndicate is usually worth more than being third in three.

EXAMPLE: A QUICK FLIP

You found a low-tier hive of 2 nodes, take your finder's cut, and buy 3 more crypto at ¥200 each (¥600). Nobody else buys in. Next turn it is hivejacked while still at 2 nodes. As the only holder you collect ROOT and SUDO (¥3,000), then cash out your 4 crypto for ¥800. You spent ¥600 and got ¥3,800 back.

Middle: pick your moment

- **Look at the holdings.** Crypto holdings are public. Before you broker a hive to a syndicate, or set off a hivejack, check who would be paid. Don't hand a rival a bonus.
- **One crypto more than the leader takes ROOT.** A tie for ROOT splits the money. If you can see you are tied, a single extra crypto takes the whole ROOT bonus.
- **Grow it before it's absorbed.** Payouts and cash out prices use the absorbed hive's size before the hivejack. If you hold its crypto, push it up to the next step of the price chart first. Check the

chart: a low-tier hive pays the same at 6 nodes as at 10, so growing it from 6 to 10 earns you nothing.

- **Don't grow a rival's hive.** Every spread raises the price and moves a hive toward a hivejack or Black ICE. Make sure it is your hive you are helping.
- **Keep options in your exploit kit.** Some exploits touch nothing and just pass the turn quietly. Others found, spread, or hivejack. Holding a mix lets you choose when things happen instead of being forced.
- **Count exploits.** There is exactly one exploit for each node. If a key node stays empty turn after turn, someone may be holding its exploit for the right moment.

Hivejack choices

- **Swap when the absorbed crypto was cheap.** A swap is always 2 for 1, whatever the sizes. Two crypto worth ¥300 each (¥600 if you cash out) for one worth ¥800 is a good trade, and it might make you ROOT of the absorber.
- **HODL if you can bring it back.** If your exploit kit can found a new hive, keeping flatlined crypto and then brokering that syndicate again gives you a head start on ROOT. Selling now and buying back later costs turns.
- **Cash early, swap late.** In the first few hivejacks, new yen buys you more crypto. Later, one hive usually gets big enough to last the game. Get into it with a swap before the end, or make sure you hold ROOT somewhere else that is big.

Late: the null-route

- **Black ICE hives survive.** At 11 nodes a hive can never be absorbed, so its ROOT bonus is settled at the final cash out. A hive one node short of Black ICE is the best target on the Grid, for you or for a rival.
- **Flatlined crypto is worth nothing at the end.** HODLing late in the game is a gamble that the syndicate comes back in time.
- **Only call the null-route if you are ahead.** Add up your ¥, your crypto at current prices, and the bonuses you would collect. If someone else comes out on top, keep playing.
- **Use the other cowboys' turns.** The shot clock only runs on your decisions, so plan your next spike while others move. With move hints on, each empty node your exploit kit can hit shows the number of the exploit that hits it.

Some of these tips are adapted from Robert Crowter-Jones's *Acquire* strategy notes (Elusive Meeple, 2018).

11 Glossary

Access Cowboy You, the player.

Black ICE A hive of 11+ nodes. Can't be absorbed.

Broker Assign a newly founded hive to a syndicate.

Burn the kit Discard an unusable exploit kit and draw 6 new exploits.

Cash out Sell crypto to the Darkpool.

Darkpool The bank.

Exploit One card in your exploit kit, good for one node.

Exploit kit Your hand of 6 exploits.

Finder's cut The free crypto for founding a hive.

Flatlined Crypto of a syndicate not on the Grid.

Grid The board: one region's network.

Hive A syndicate's connected group of nodes.

Hivejack One hive absorbing another.

HODL Keep absorbed crypto instead of selling or swapping.

Infiltration Founding a new hive.

Lockdown Every hive is Black ICE; the game may end.

Grid Stall A full round with no exploit run; the game ends.

Node One square of the Grid.

Null-route The end of the game.

Patched out An exploit that can never be run.

ROOT Biggest holder of a syndicate's crypto; gets the big bonus.

Spike A placed exploit; a lone spike belongs to no hive.

Spread A hive growing by one or more nodes.

SUDO Second-biggest holder; gets the small bonus.

Swap Trade 2 absorbed crypto for 1 absorber crypto.

Total Compromise A hive of 41+ nodes; the game may end.

12 Reference Chart

Find the hive's size in its tier's column, then read across for the crypto price and the payouts.

Hive size (nodes)			Crypto	Payout	
Low	Mid	High	price	ROOT	SUDO
GR	DIB	LO			
2	–	–	¥200	¥2,000	¥1,000
3	2	–	¥300	¥3,000	¥1,500
4	3	2	¥400	¥4,000	¥2,000
5	4	3	¥500	¥5,000	¥2,500
6–10	5	4	¥600	¥6,000	¥3,000
11–20	6–10	5	¥700	¥7,000	¥3,500
21–30	11–20	6–10	¥800	¥8,000	¥4,000
31–40	21–30	11–20	¥900	¥9,000	¥4,500
41+	31–40	21–30	¥1,000	¥10,000	¥5,000
–	41+	31–40	¥1,100	¥11,000	¥5,500
–	–	41+	¥1,200	¥12,000	¥6,000

11+ nodes Black ICE: the hive can't be absorbed.
41+ nodes Total Compromise: the null-route may be called.
ROOT bonus 10 × crypto price. **SUDO bonus**: 5 × crypto price.

SYN-ACK WIRE is an unofficial fan re-skin of *Acquire*, designed by Sid Sackson (1964).
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